took place. Some senior officials in the Obama administration contend that scalable sanctions deterred Putin from gambling he could take Kiev in two weeks and pushed him instead to the negotiating table. The most notable example in this case, which reverberated through some of the BRICS, was serious consideration by the United States and the European Union of turning off Russia's access to the SWIFT financial messaging system in response to its intervention in Ukraine and annexation of Crimea. In this respect, the U.S. approach resembles Thomas Schelling's risk strategy of imposing significant punishment while threatening much higher costs so that submission appears the best option. However, Washington's credibility in making coercive threats was perhaps impaired by its greater concern about the reaction of global financial markets.

Moreover, as Daniel Drezner points out, sanctions can have negative blowback effects that may impose greater future costs on senders.[92] Other analysts similarly suggest that American unilateralism supported by the "weaponization of finance" could provoke balancing against the United States in the form of diversifying away from the dollar.[93] Prime Minister Dmitri Medvedev threatened to escalate to the "unlimited" use of force in the event of a SWIFT cutoff.[94] On the eve of the BRICS 2014 summit in Brazil, Putin signaled the urgent need to reduce Russia's vulnerability to sanctions, telling interviewers: "Together we [the BRICS] should think about a system of measures that would help prevent the harassment of countries that do not agree with some foreign policy decisions made by the United States and their allies… ."[95]

After U.S. sanctions led to the interruption of Visa and MasterCard operations in Russia, meaning that Russian bank–issued credit cards could no longer be used abroad because their payments with sanctioned banks would not be processed, Putin complained that these were not "depoliticized economic entities," but instead "are strongly affected by political pressure."[96] The fact that Visa and MasterCard had the largest market share and could disrupt even Russian officials' use of their cards while overseas came as a shock to the Kremlin. As a consequence, the Russian government rapidly tasked the Bank of Russia to establish a national payment card system from scratch. Demonstrating a commitment to develop a viable global system, this was followed by cobranding agreements with a number of international payments systems, including Visa and MasterCard; Japan Credit Bureau